Fasting & Calorie Deficit

What they are, how they differ, and how to stay healthy as a teenager.

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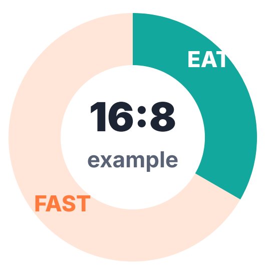
1 What is Fasting?



Fasting means choosing **not to eat** (or eating very little) for a set period of time, then eating again.

It is about **WHEN** you eat.

- 16:8 — fast 16 h, eat in 8 h
- 5:2 — eat less 2 days/week
- Religious fasting (e.g. Ramadan)

2 What is Calorie Deficit?

A **calorie deficit** means you take in **fewer calories** (energy from food) than your body uses each day. It is about **HOW MUCH** you eat.

Calories IN food & drinks < **Calories OUT** body + activity = **Deficit** body uses stored fat

How it works: when food energy is not enough, the body uses its stored energy (fat) to make up the gap — so weight slowly goes down. A small deficit is safer than a big one.

3 Fasting vs Calorie Deficit

	Fasting	Calorie Deficit
Main focus	**Timing** — when you eat	**Amount** — how much energy you eat
Daily routine	Long breaks with no food, then an eating window	Regular meals, just smaller portions or lighter food
Weight loss?	Only if it also leads to eating fewer calories overall	Yes — a deficit is *the* reason weight goes down
Who should avoid	Teens, people with diabetes, eating disorders, pregnancy	Anyone going too low (crash diets), growing teens without advice

Key idea: fasting is one *way* to create a calorie deficit — but it is not the only way, and it is not "magic".

4 Possible Benefits

Healthy weight control
Helps adults with overweight lose weight slowly.

Better heart & blood sugar
May improve blood pressure, cholesterol and insulin levels in adults.

Stops mindless snacking
A clear eating schedule can reduce late-night snacking.

! Possible Risks

Low energy & poor focus
Tiredness, headaches, dizziness and bad mood ("hangry").

Missing nutrients & muscle
Too little protein, iron or calcium; the body may lose muscle, not just fat.

Unhealthy food habits
Overeating after fasting, or a higher risk of eating disorders.

5 Myth vs Fact

× MYTH	✓ FACT
"Skipping meals is the fastest and best way to lose weight."	Weight loss depends on total calories over time. Skipping meals often leads to overeating later.
"The fewer calories I eat, the healthier I am."	Eating too little slows your metabolism and causes tiredness, weak muscles and missing nutrients.
"During fasting hours I can't drink anything."	In most intermittent fasting plans, water is allowed and staying hydrated is important.
"Fasting burns fat in a special way, so calories don't matter."	Studies show fasting and normal calorie cutting give **similar** weight loss when total calories are the same.

6 Teenagers & a Healthy Lifestyle

Teenagers are still **growing** — bones, muscles, brain and hormones all need enough energy and nutrients every day. Extreme dieting or strict calorie restriction can do real harm:

Slower growth
Less bone strength and height gain; possible delayed puberty or missed periods.

Weaker brain power
Poor concentration, memory and school performance; low energy for sport.

Mental health risk
Dieting in teens is linked to eating disorders and is a risk for future weight gain.

- Balanced meals: ½ veggies & fruit, ¼ protein, ¼ grains
- Move 60 minutes every day
- Sleep 8–10 hours a night
- Drink water, limit sugary drinks

Golden rule: focus on healthy **habits**, not a number on the scale. Before trying any diet or fasting plan, talk to a parent, doctor or school nurse.

Sources

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